

GENESIS 1

SEMITIC JEW

A Scripture-First Study Guide

Study the opening chapter of Scripture by comparing Scripture with Scripture, tracing the logic of creation, and distinguishing what the biblical text says from assumptions placed upon it.

STUDY GUIDE NO. 1

How to Use This Guide

This guide is designed for individual study, families, Bible-study groups, classrooms, and readers who want to examine Genesis carefully rather than merely repeat inherited conclusions.

1. **Read the text first.** Begin each section by reading the listed passage in your Bible.
2. **Observe before interpreting.** Identify what God says, separates, names, blesses, commands, and evaluates.
3. **Compare Scripture with Scripture.** Use the cross-references to see how later biblical writers understand creation.
4. **Distinguish claims.** Separate what Genesis explicitly states from reasonable inference and from modern scientific models.
5. **Write your reasoning.** The study questions are meant to make the reader explain conclusions from the text.

Nehemiah 8:8 — “So they read in the book in the law of God distinctly, and gave the sense...”

The Controlling Principle

Genesis 1 is the beginning of the biblical canon, not an isolated religious poem. Its categories—light, darkness, heaven, earth, sea, life, kind, man, image, dominion, blessing, work, and rest—are developed throughout Scripture.

A Scripture-first method therefore asks two questions:

What does Genesis say?

Observe the grammar, sequence, repeated formulas, categories, commands, and evaluations in the chapter itself.

How does Scripture reuse it?

Compare Exodus 20:8–11; Psalm 33:6–9; Psalm 104; Isaiah 40:26; John 1:1–3; Hebrews 11:3; and Revelation 4:11.

The goal is coherence: do not make one verse contradict another when a fuller context can explain both.

A Mature Creation

Semitic Jew reads Genesis as describing a creation brought into existence in a **functionally mature state** within seven consecutive ordinary 24-hour periods. The first humans are capable of receiving commands. Vegetation bears seed. Animals can multiply. Heavenly lights perform their appointed functions. The world begins as an ordered habitation, not as an unusable infant system.

This position makes an important logical distinction:

Observed maturity ≠ necessarily elapsed history

If God creates a mature man, his adult body does not prove that he personally experienced decades of prior growth. In the same way, a created world may contain structures that, if one assumed uninterrupted natural development from an earlier state, could be assigned an apparent history longer than its actual elapsed history.

Boundary: This is a theological inference from the creation narrative. It is not itself a laboratory measurement or a substitute for describing how scientific dating methods operate.

Word Study: יום • yom

Transliteration: *yom*

The Hebrew word for “day” has a normal semantic range: daylight, a day-night cycle, or a broader period depending on context. Therefore the word alone does not settle every chronology question.

In Genesis 1, however, the context is decisive. The days are numbered, the repeated evening-and-morning formula marks ordinary successive days, and Exodus 20:8–11 grounds a literal human workweek in the creation pattern. **Semitic Jew therefore reads the creation week as seven consecutive 24-hour periods, not as symbolic ages or vast spans of time.**

Compare: Gen 1:5, 8, 13, 19, 23, 31; Gen 2:4; Ex 20:8–11.

Method: Word meaning is controlled by usage and context, not by selecting whichever dictionary gloss supports a preferred conclusion.

Study Questions I

1. List every action God performs in Genesis 1:1–5.
2. What things are divided or distinguished on Day One and Day Two?
3. What does God name?
4. What repeated phrases create structure in the chapter?
5. How does vegetation demonstrate immediate functionality?
6. Explain the difference between observing the text and inferring from the text.
7. Compare Genesis 1:3 with 2 Corinthians 4:6. How does Paul reuse creation language?

Notes